



BEFORE

American history offered many examples of successful insurgency and counter-insurgency that both sides in the Civil War could draw on for guidance and inspiration.

THE REVOLUTIONARY WAR

During the American Revolution, **irregular fighters** such as Francis Marion (famous as the “Swamp Fox”), Thomas Sumter, and Daniel Morgan led their men on repeated and successful **hit-and-run raids** against British supply columns and isolated outposts.

A precedent had therefore been established, especially in the South, for guerrilla-type warfare. The memory of Kings Mountain and Cowpens, where regular British and Loyalist units were decimated by **effective guerrilla tactics**, lived long in the Southern mind, as did the exploits of those who led these and other operations.

MEXICAN WAR COUNTERINSURGENCY

The regular U.S. Army undertook numerous antiguerrilla and stability operations during the War with Mexico (1846–48) that, if not codified, still **created procedures** for combating an irregular threat. General Winfield Scott issued a series of directives on **how to deal with enemy insurgents** and the civilians who harbored them that **effectively eliminated** most irregular Mexican resistance.

As soon as the Union armies occupied parts of the South, Southern irregulars rose up to oppose them. Drawing on memories of earlier conflicts, intimate knowledge of local conditions, and aware of every ambush site and hiding place, these fighters focused on lightning-fast raids against isolated garrisons and supply areas. They rarely wore uniforms and easily blended back into the civilian population.

Lincoln’s administration at first advised restraint and kindness toward both captured irregulars and the civilian populations that harbored them. The idea was to restore good faith and belief in the Federal government.

Before he rose to lead the Army of the Potomac, Major General George B. McClellan exhorted his command in Western Virginia to “use every effort to conciliate the people and strengthen Union feeling.” He continued, “You are here to protect, not destroy. Take nothing, destroy nothing ... respect the right of private opinion.”

Unfortunately for the Union, such policies, along with Lincoln’s propensity to pardon captured guerrillas who had been sentenced to death, generally emboldened local irregulars instead of pacifying them. Even when Union garrisons rebuilt shattered Southern